Between them, Nizamuddin and Munim won the information war; and, lucky for them, the prophesied heads did roll soon enough. Still, that Agra was gripped with such anxiety while it waited doesn't indicate widespread confidence in the stability of Akbar's rule. As one modern historian puts it, north India had grown accustomed, over centuries, to the 'ephemeral nature' of dynasties; the land was littered with 'pretenders', all with some connection, however tenuous, with dynasties that had once reigned, all of them convinced that 'the Mughal . . . [was] only a temporary occupant of the supreme seat of power, to be replaced, as fortune might direct, possibly by one of themselves, possibly by a new invader'.[4]

Besides local opposition to Mughal rule, there was, of course, the competition that the Mughals brought along with them. The Uzbeks might have been subdued, but Akbar's Timurid relatives, the troublesome Mirzas, were only waiting in the wings to take their place; as, after them, Akbar's nobility in Bengal would rise against him. Indeed, in the half-century that Akbar ruled, it was the rare year – the rare month – that did not include some discontent brewing, if not always bursting, in some part of his realm.

Akbar, meanwhile, never slackened in weeding out opposition to his rule. Not for him the careful calibration of power that had characterized the political understanding of Humayun and Babur, for whom their chiefs were more allies than subordinates. Abul Fazl may write of Akbar offering his own water to Bahadur and not wanting the Uzbek killed, but there was absolutely no show of pity in how Akbar treated Bahadur's supporters. Many of these men were old companions of Humayun's, and may have remembered how Humayun understood and forgave wavering allegiance. ''Tis the fortune of war,' he had said once, 'such accidents . . . must happen.'

But this was the world of Akbar, and such accidents were terminal. Akbar held court in Jaunpur, meting out his punishment. The rebels were trampled by musth elephants – 'What bloodshed took place!'[5] was a chronogram for the date. One of them, Mirak Mashhadi, suffered nerve-racking torture. For five days, one after the other, he was brought before the padishah in chains, and set upon by an elephant – without orders to kill. The elephant only 'caught him in his trunk and squeezed him . . . and flung him from one side to the other', the petrified man expecting his death at any moment, yet